lenient with him. His very quick ball, and sometimes his bouncer, stretch the boundaries of legality. And I remember former Aussie opener Justin Langer's comments after a game against Pakistan. 'We,' he said, with a very obvious smirk, 'handled everything he could *throw* at us.'

But, ag you know, players like Shoaib are good for the game and people want to see him bowl. I have always liked making it interesting for the spectators. And he really is an entertaining bowler.

Shoaib even seemed to fake injury in order to confuse batsmen. At times, particularly on the subcontinent, it was really hot and humid, and he'd come running in with his bladdy spikes hitting his arse – I mean, really charging in off that long run-up of his, which gave you, the batsman, plenty of time to think, 'This boy is coming, and he's coming for *you*.'

He'd bowl four really quick overs with that slinging action of his and you'd really be kakking off … and then he'd suddenly pull up like he's tweaked his hamstring. Now you're thinking, 'Great, he's pulled a hammy, or he's cramping. I can relax a little.' Maybe he'd send down a couple of slower ones and by now you're thinking, 'Brilliant, he's going to be heading for the changing room soon …'

And then the next ball is a lightning bolt aimed either at your head or, worse, your toes.

I remember one of the first times I played against Shoaib was in 2000, at the Sharjah tournament in the United Arab Emirates. It was a day/night ODI game against Pakistan, and there he was, charging at Gary Kirsten, my fellow opener, and me. In that first over that Shoaib bowled, not one delivery was slower than 153km/h. I mean, he was blitzing in. So … after two overs he grabbed his hammy and we thought, 'Okay, cool, it'll be nice to relax.' And then he comes back and bowls just as fast. We suddenly lost three or four quick wickets. Actually, I remember that particular game as one of the few times when I carried my bat through an ODI. I opened the batting and was still there at our innings' close.

As I mentioned, I always found Shoaib trickier to face on the subcontinent wickets because the bounce isn't always consistent. Some balls stay low, others bounce, and then it becomes like a lottery, you know. It's almost like you've got to decide what you're going to do beforehand.

Let's say Shoaib throws the ball in short; you're going to pull it and rely on your reactions to execute the shot. At that speed, you can't play each ball on its merit – they just come too fast. You have less than a second to make